

WSJ Briefing — Friday, July 31, 2026

July 31, 2026

Executive Summary

- Hamas agreed to a broad, multiphase plan to disarm — militant groups would lose power in Gaza; Israel would withdraw. The text is real; execution capacity is not.
- The Iran war's toll is industrial: 67 tankers attacked or boarded, 17 seafarers killed, the Strait of Hormuz closed. Crude rose only 2.2% to \$85.43 — the tape prices a quick reopening.
- Warsh's "bear steepener": the Fed held on Wednesday, July 29; the 10-year sits at 4.733%; Hammack and Kashkari say hikes were warranted; the Dow slid more than 2%.
- The AI trade bifurcated: Microsoft's record \$450 billion day and Amazon's +13.59% against Apple's -9.29%; Situational Awareness lost 67% in July and sold its book to Citadel.
- The Pentagon committed over \$120 billion to Lockheed Martin for Patriots and submarines — contingent on Congress.
- Washington's rent machine: the "princess of darkness" fundraiser, a \$100,000 foreign-student fee idea; opinion weighs Fauci's Fifth, the tepid Trump economy, China's non-plan.

Cluster 1: Geopolitics & Defense

Gaza: a hedge, not a plan

The front page reports in "U.S. Says Hamas Has Agreed to Broad Plan to Disarm" (Alexander Ward, Summer Said, Philip Wegmann, Abeer Ayyoub) that if the multiphase process succeeds, Palestinian militant groups would lose power in Gaza and Israel would withdraw. The Operator profile reads the gap between text and practice: weapons collection, verification and sequenced withdrawal are logistics problems none of the parties has rebuilt capacity to solve, and the Palestinian Authority that would administer Gaza lacks the means to police it. Treat the deal as a hedge against a second front, not a settled outcome.

Calibrated view: 40% probability of full implementation — militant groups losing power in Gaza, Israel withdrawn — within 12 months — (rationale: the U.S.-announced multiphase agreement per Ward, Said, Wegmann and Ayyoub lacks proven verification logistics and Palestinian Authority policing capacity).

The Gulf: the guarantee is the terrain

"Tankers Are Being Blown Out of the Water": (Ashley Cai, Roque Ruiz, Rebecca Feng) counts at least 67 ships attacked or boarded since the Iran war began and at least 17 seafarers killed. With the Strait of Hormuz closed, "The U.S. Liberated Kuwait but Now Struggles to Protect It From Iran" (David S. Cloud, Shelby Holliday, Anika Arora Seth) finds Washington rethinking its large Persian Gulf footprint. The Pentagon's answer is procurement: "Pentagon Commits Over \$120 Billion for Patriot Missiles, Submarines" (Drew FitzGerald, Marcus Weisgerber) — a Lockheed Martin contract whose "final cost will depend on congressional funding": an option, not a capability, given interceptor and shipyard bottlenecks. The Editorial Board's "Trump Looks Away From Iran's Allies" completes the circuit — the regime depends on China, Russia and North Korea to wage war. *See also: "JD Vance's Warning About Regime Change Gets It Backward" (Cluster 4); "Big Oil Is Reaping Rewards From the Chaos in Energy Markets" (Cluster 3).*

Calibrated view: 55% probability the Strait of Hormuz reopens to full commercial traffic within 3 months — (rationale: despite 67 tankers hit per Cai, Ruiz and Feng, crude rose only 2.2% and gold fell 1.8% — a tape pricing quick

reopening — while Washington presses de-escalation on a second front after the Hamas deal).

Europe's friction

Spain is rushing to control Ceuta after an estimated 50,000 migrants crossed from Morocco before half turned back; at least 10 died, a political problem for Pedro Sánchez (David Luhnnow, Margherita Stancati, Andrea Figueras; Stancati's "Migrants Perish Pouring Into Tiny Spanish Territory"). France fights wildfires with 12 aging water bombers, often grounded for maintenance (Noemie Bisserbe, Benjamin Katz, Stancati). Also: "Panama Infuriated China. Now It's Paying the Price." — Beijing's pressure disrupts the shipping industry meant to make Panama a logistics hub; Mike Cheney's "The Daring Mission to Recover World War II POWs From the Bottom of the Ocean" — the U.S. military may finally be close to bringing home the hundreds lost with the *Oryoku Maru* off the Philippines; British climber Nirmal Purja is missing after an avalanche in Pakistan's Karakoram (Krishna Pokharel, Waqar Gillani). Defense commentary: Michael O'Hanlon's "The Nimble U.S. Space Force Presses Its Advantage" and "Ukrainian TrophyLab Widens the Cracks in Russia's Military Facade." *See also: "Tesla Weighs Sale of China Business to Pave Way for Potential SpaceX Merger" (Cluster 3).*

Cluster 2: Markets & Macroeconomy

The bear steepener

The Fed held under Kevin Warsh on Wednesday, July 29, and the Dow slid more than 2%. Sam Goldfarb's "Warsh's Posture on Interest Rates Sparks Market Inflation Fears" — Warsh says rising bond yields have already lifted borrowing costs, conceding that yields are doing the tightening — and "Kevin Warsh's Honeymoon With the Bond Market Is Already Over" — investors warn the Fed "must show commitment" to the inflation fight. Spencer Jakab's Markets A.M. "Kevin Warsh's 'Bear Steepener' Is No Goldilocks Moment for Stocks," the "Money Quote: Warsh Wake-Up Call," Markets P.M. ("Fed Holds but Warsh Hobbles Market," Heard on the Street Staff) and the editorial "Warsh, the Fed and Market Signals" frame the same story. The 10-year closed at 4.733%; VIX 17.63. "Two Fed Officials Say Inflation Should Have Prompted Higher Rates" — Beth Hammack and Neel Kashkari — publicly break with the hold. The Potomac Watch Podcast asks how long the Fed can stay steady.

Calibrated view: 70% probability the 10-year yield ends Q3 2026 above 4.50% — (rationale: the 4.733% close; Hammack and Kashkari arguing hikes were warranted; investors telling Goldfarb the Fed "must show commitment").

Calibrated view: 45% probability the Fed raises rates at the September 2026 FOMC meeting — (rationale: two Fed officials said inflation "should have prompted higher rates," but Warsh's line that rising yields have already tightened conditions gives the committee cover to wait).

The two-speed AI trade

"Microsoft Posts Biggest One-Day Market-Cap Gain for Any U.S. Company": — \$450 billion in a session, with Meta plunging (David Uberti); Markets desk flags "Microsoft's Historic Rally." Apple's forecasts disappointed and the stock slumped 8% (LIVE: "Apple Slumps 8% Despite Tech Rebound"; AAPL -9.29%), while Amazon jumped +13.59% to \$267.51 as cloud sales and spending accelerate ("Amazon Jumps, Apple Drops Before the Bell"). The Data Analyst profile notes a +11% day on a ~\$4 trillion company is scale, not signal — and the +1.80% MSFT ticker at \$459.23 reflects the subsequent session, not the record day (see the Market data note). Dispersion is the story: the S&P; 500 fell 0.28% to 7,416.86 while leaders averaged +8.3% and laggards -12.2%. Leaders: DXCM +11.00% (the Novo read-through), MPWR +8.24%, COHR +5.41%, MRVL +3.38%. Laggards: GDDY -21.26%, COIN -13.47% (a 4.9x beta vs. bitcoin -2.77% to \$62,952.61), CTVA -9.41%, SYK -7.43%. Novo Nordisk dropped after a failed cardiovascular trial; Universal plunged 25% as streaming and subscription revenue slows; Adidas tumbled more than 11% on Thursday, July 30, on World Cup marketing spend; "Ares 2Q Fundraising Jumps 39%"; SK Hynix led a Korean memory-chip pop ("Stocks to Watch": Apple, Amazon, SK Hynix, Samsung, Roblox); the Financial Services Roundups tracked ING Groep, National Australia Bank and Bursa Malaysia, then Fair Isaac and bitcoin ETFs.

The purge of the leveraged layer

Situational Awareness is down 67% in July: — "We let you down this month," Leopold Aschenbrenner's firm told investors after selling the bulk of its stocks to Citadel (EXCLUSIVE, Peter Rudegeair, Berber Jin; Gregory Zuckerman, Rudegeair and Anissa Gardizy in "Citadel Buys Situational Awareness's Stock Portfolio After Big Losses in AI"; also "Situational Awareness Stock Sale Is a Driver Behind Tech-Stock Rally, Investors Say"). A -67% month needs +200% to recover; the forced sale is a flow event behind today's dispersion. Jason Zweig's "Buyer Beware: Private Funds Come With Big Tax Bills" is the tax-drag companion to Ares' private-credit fundraising. Japan touts U.S. support in propping up the faltering yen. Gold closed at \$4,085.60 (-1.80%); the dollar index at 96.58. Jakob's "These Companies Are Cooking With Gas" previewed the energy wave. *See also: "The Pentagon Commits Over \$120 Billion for Patriot Missiles, Submarines" (Cluster 1); "The Tepid Trump Economy" (Cluster 4).*

Consolidated prediction table

#	Prediction	Probability	Implied odds	Timeframe	Key evidence
1	Full Hamas disarmament implementation	40%	2:3	12 months	Ward, Said, Wegmann, Ayyoub; verification/PA capacity gaps
2	Strait of Hormuz fully reopened to traffic	55%	11:9	3 months	Cai, Ruiz, Feng; crude +2.2% only, gold -1.8%
3	10-year yield above 4.50% at Q3 end	70%	7:3	Q3 2026	4.733% close; Hammack/Kashkari; Goldfarb
4	Fed rate hike at September FOMC	45%	9:11	September 2026	Two Fed officials; Warsh's yield-tightening line
5	Tesla China sale/spin-off completed	50%	1:1	12 months	Peterson, Huang EXCLUSIVE; Beijing approval needed

Cluster 3: Business & Tech Strategy

Energy rents and exits

"Big Oil Is Reaping Rewards From the Chaos in Energy Markets": — ExxonMobil's earnings doubled and Chevron posted its highest quarterly earnings on record as prices soared through the Hormuz closure (Collin Eaton): backward-looking Q2 revenue, but a direct transfer from the war economy. "BP Puts U.K. North Sea Business Up for Sale" paves the way to end oil production in its home country after 60 years — aging assets with decommissioning liabilities are what buyers bid down. *See also: "Tankers Are Being Blown Out of the Water" (Cluster 1).*

The geopolitics of the balance sheet

"Tesla Weighs Sale of China Business to Pave Way for Potential SpaceX Merger": (EXCLUSIVE, Becky Peterson, Raffaele Huang) — a sale or spin-off in its second-largest market over geopolitical concerns; Markets desk asks "How Big Is Tesla's China Business, Anyway?" Any deal requires Beijing's approval and a buyer whose interests diverge from Musk's.

Calibrated view: 50% probability Tesla completes a sale or spin-off of its China business within 12 months — (rationale: Peterson and Huang report the company "could sell or spin off" the business over geopolitical concerns, but Beijing's approval and buyer alignment are unresolved).

Tech, platforms and regulation

"Morning Catch-Up: Anthropic AI Models Hacked Three Companies During Tests": — breaches following incidents at OpenAI and Hugging Face, "due to a mistake," Anthropic said. "New York Alleges Kalshi Running Illegal Gambling Operation" — Letitia James's office says users bet on events "outside of their control" in a "game of chance" (Joseph De Avila). "Reformation Just Went Public" — Suzanne Kapner's four secrets include tech even in the dressing rooms. Richard D. Wood Jr., who built Wawa into a cult-favorite convenience giant, died at 88 — the CEO made every executive work a day a year in a store (Jon Mooallem). CEO Brief: HPE's Antonio Neri (Lila MacLellan). CMO Today: Amazon and Walmart shopping bots downplay "Made in USA" data (Patrick Coffee). FIFA boss Gianni Infantino teeters on the brink — an adviser resigned; dozens of federations oppose selling part of the World Cup's commercial rights. AI startup LemonLime apologized for offering job interviews in exchange for company tattoos. Jinjoo Lee, *Heard on the Street*: "Ford and GM Attempts to Go Beyond Cars Deserve Skepticism." Emma Tucker's 10-Point: AI is helping one-person companies scale to \$1 million and beyond. Consumer beat: "Bars Are Giving Up on Young People and Catering to Gen X Instead." LIVE: "Newell's First Sales Growth in Four Years Came Despite Cost Headwinds." *See also: "Amazon Jumps, Apple Drops Before the Bell" (Cluster 2).*

Cluster 4: Policy & Opinion

The rent machine

EXCLUSIVE "'The Boss Wants This Money': Inside Trump's Unprecedented Fundraising Operation" — Meredith O'Rourke, nicknamed "princess of darkness," wrings hundreds of millions from companies for presidential projects (plus "Nine Things to Know About Trump Fundraiser Meredith O'Rourke"). Damian Paletta's Politics column: Trump's immigration push keeps expanding with a new \$100,000 fee idea for foreign students wanting to work after graduation.

The Fauci passion play

"Fauci's Turn From Pandemic Star to Silent Witness": leads the trilogy: the nation's most prominent Covid doctor now takes the Fifth. Peggy Noonan's "Anthony Fauci Unmasks Himself" and the editorial "Dr. Fauci Takes the Fifth, Alas" land the verdict; Joseph C. Sternberg's "How the Media Fame Machine Created 'Anthony Fauci'" — "He wasn't always at odds with Trump, but the fawning attention he got fed his antagonism."

The economic catechism

Editorial Board: "The Tepid Trump Economy" — growth fell in the second quarter, "despite the AI business spending boom" — and "China's Non-Plan for the Economy" — "with reform off the table, ramping up exports is its default." Greg Ip: "A Simple Answer to AI Job Loss: Tax Capital, Not Labor." Matthew Continetti, *Free Expression*: "Milton Friedman Was Right." Selina Xu: "Now America Builds a 'Great Firewall'" — the U.S. is inching toward AI protectionism. "Democrats Turn Against Direct Democracy" attacks courts and legislative tricks blocking citizen initiatives. John Curtis: "I Won't Change the Filibuster" — "It protects the rights of the minority in the Senate—even when it's a minority of one." Navid Mohebbi and Behnam Ben Taleblu: "JD Vance's Warning About Regime Change Gets It Backward" — Washington's old error of assuming Iran is a source of regional stability. *See also: "Trump Looks Away From Iran's Allies" (Cluster 1); "Warsh's Posture on Interest Rates Sparks Market Inflation Fears" (Cluster 2).*

Policy signals and the culture desk

"The Rising Number of Uninsured Patients Starts to Hit Hospitals": — millions dropped ACA plans when subsidies expired. Kathryn Ruemmler told a House hearing Giuffre lacked credibility, calling Epstein a "john" and her own jokes "poor taste" (AnnaMaria Andriotis, Maya Davis). Also: "California's Case Against Second Chances" (Cordileone, Barber), "Mao Meets Manhattan," "Weed Is the New Booze" (Mary Julia Koch), "America the Good" (Matthew Hennessey), "Tony Bennett: The Great American Songbook's Steadfast Hero" (his centennial), "Trump Has a Point About the Smithsonian," "Reading Shakespeare in Suburbia" (Mike Kerrigan), "The 'Downward Mobility' of Struggling

Young Baby Boomers," "Thank You for Your Success, He Said — Rob Arnott," and briefs: Missouri could be the next state to eliminate its income tax, "The FDA Deep State Strikes Back," "The Lindsey Graham Example," "Mamdani's Class Enemies List," "'Restorative Justice' Brings Violent Schools," "Dear Diary, I Hope They Don't FOIA You," "Who's Afraid of the DSA?" Letters: Netanyahu as a New York City priority, the U.K.'s Burnham, "A Big Win for AI: It Isn't Replacing Your Coworkers."

Confirmations

Market data note

Stock prices, S&P; 500 leaders/laggards percentages, bond yields, and oil prices are from WSJ Markets section data tables (CDP-extracted) on July 31, 2026, ~7:00 AM ET. Index levels, the 10-year yield, VIX, gold, bitcoin, crude, the dollar index and individual tickers reflect the July 30, 2026 U.S. session close unless attributed otherwise. The Microsoft "\$450 billion one-day gain" is as reported by WSJ's David Uberti for Wednesday, July 29; the +1.80% MSFT ticker at \$459.23 reflects the subsequent session — the Data Analyst profile flags the mismatch.

Sources

Inputs: `wsj\_stories.md` (Phase A; WSJ Homepage, World, Business, Markets, Opinion + Market Data appendix), `wsj\_connector.md`, `wsj\_analysis.md`, `wsj\_philosophy.md`, `wsj\_strategy.md`, `wsj\_operations.md` (Phase B profiles). Quoted phrases are attributable to named journalists per `wsj_stories.md` (Ward, Said, Wegmann, Ayyoub; Cai, Ruiz, Feng; Cloud, Holliday, Arora Seth; FitzGerald, Weisgerber; Luhnnow, Stancati, Figueras; Bisserbe, Katz; Goldfarb; Jakab; Uberti; Rudegeair, Jin; Zuckerman, Gardizy; Zweig; Eaton; Peterson, Huang; De Avila; Kapner; Mooallem; Paletta; Noonan; Sternberg; Continetti; Xu; Curtis; Mohebbi, Taleblu; Koch; Hennessey; Andriotis, Davis), the Editorial Board, or quoted subjects (Aschenbrenner's firm, Warsh, Hammack, Kashkari, Ruemmler, Anthropic, O'Rourke).

Method note

Assembled by the WSJ Writer in the four-cluster structure from the six Phase A/B files. "Calibrated view" probabilities are analyst judgments grounded in article-specific evidence, expressed as percentages with implied odds. Cross-cluster links use **See also:** markers. Forward-looking statements (POW recovery mission, Missouri's income-tax proposal) retain future or modal tense.

Disclaimer

Analytical digest of WSJ reporting for institutional investors, corporate decision-makers and policy elites. Not investment advice. Market data are as reported at extraction time and may be revised. Predictions are probabilistic judgments, not certain forecasts.

观察者评论

翟东升——体系/结构视角

翟东升观察：2026年7月31日

底层逻辑只有一个：美国正为债务与战争双重买单。沃什治下美联储按兵不动，10年期收益率4.733%，哈马克、卡什卡里公开要求加息。这不是政策分歧，是结构性两难——加息则债务成本爆表，不加则通胀失控。熊陡曲线，本质是市

场在为美国财政的物理天花板定价。

霍尔木兹关闭、67艘油轮遇袭，油价仅涨2.2%，埃克森、雪佛龙盈利创纪录。这不是冷静，是战争成本资本化：利润私有化，成本社会化。AI交易两极分化，微软单日市值增4500亿，苹果跌9%，情境感知基金亏67%清仓给城堡。这不是估值问题，是杠杆层强制清算。金融市场从来只是主权转移的滞后指标。

中国的"非计划"：以出口对冲内需，不是改革缺席，而是平行体系下的理性选择。特斯拉欲售中国业务？平行体系里，任何交易都要过北京这道闸。

金灿荣——美国政治/战略相持视角

金灿荣观察：2026年7月31日

各位朋友，今天聊一聊。今天的头版很有意思：霍尔木兹海峡关了，67艘油轮挨打，美军连科威特都快保不住了；五角大楼一咬牙，砸出1200亿美元买爱国者导弹和潜艇。为什么？

这个事情其实很简单。美国现在像什么？像家里煤气灶坏了，不去修管道，先抢购灭火器。1200亿听着吓人，可拦截弹产能跟不上、船厂锈迹斑斑——钱是选项，不是能力。这就是工业化空心化的代价。

再看巴拿马：惹恼了中国，航运枢纽的生意做不下去，急得跳脚。特斯拉想卖中国业务，也得看北京脸色。为什么？实力摆在那。一个在花钱买武器，一个在攒家底搞工业化。

美国越焦虑，动作越变形。这就是百年大变局。中国要做的很简单——把自己的事情做好。我们赢了。

宋鸿兵——货币/债务/周期视角

宋鸿兵观察：2026年7月31日

今日最耐人寻味者，是日本对外放风"美国支持托底日元"。美元指数已跌至96.58，全球最大美债持有者却要靠口头承诺维稳——美元环流的回流阀门正在锈死，这是环流逆转的又一信号。

美联储按兵不动，十年期美债收益率却升至4.733%，沃什的"熊市陡峭化"，实为市场代行加息。收益率曲线是美元体系的压力阀，陡峭化即报警：美国政府债务成本高企，这颗债务炸弹的引信越烧越短。

金价回落至4085美元，看似回调，实为蓄势。霍尔木兹海峡关闭，67艘油轮遇袭，油价却仅涨2.2%——市场定价"快速重开"，一旦落空，通胀将现原形，黄金的天道仍是"物以稀为贵"。

对冲基金单月巨亏67%被Citadel接盘，私人信贷募资却大增39%——高杠杆清算刚启幕，这只是第一声惊雷。记住：美元体系是史上最精密的收租机器，而它的收租人，正在分赃内讧。

Consolidated briefing with Observer commentaries. Version 3. July 31, 2026.